Nicole Valentinuzzi article April 2002 reporting of the first Ottawa Italian Canadian Women's Filò where Jennie Prosperine and Maria Ierullo were honoured for their work in the Ottawa Community. the Honourable Maria Minna was the also being honoured for being the first Italian Canadian Woman Federal Cabinet Minister. The organizers were Ariella DalFarra Hostetter and Anna Chiappa			With the success of the first event, there was support and demand to hold these dinners on a yearly basis. It is now in its 17th year,

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Community / Comunità

A Filò: Honouring Italian-Canadian Women

By Nicole Valentinuzzi

A filò, as many Italians know, is an opportunity for people to tell stories and to share. This filò was organized by Ariella Hostetter and Anna Chiappa to "hold an event to acknowledge Italian-Canadian contributions to Canada."

When you think about the guests of honour – like the Honourable Maria Minna, Maria Ierullo and Jennie Prosperine – you expect a formal event with a planned itinerary followed to the letter, in order to properly commemorate their contributions to the Italian-Canadian community. Then you factor in that there are over a hundred women, mostly Italian but many other nationalities as well, and you realize any itinerary might as well be thrown out the window.

As Chiappa said, "It started out as a small evening, but mushroomed into a wonderful event."

The scene was crowded and bustling, as you can imagine it would be with that many women in one room. People were coming in off the street looking for any available extra seats, just to be a part of the action, which simply added to the casual and fun atmosphere. Chiappa's only order was that everyone must "have fun."

Lucy Zilio from Omni 1 Television took the stand as the mistress of ceremonies and expressed how delighted she was to be included in the event as an, "honourary member of the village." She hosted the evening with jokes, laughter and lighthearted entertainment.

There was loud, boisterous singing of traditional Italian songs like *Casetta in Canada*, thanks to choir mistress Vittoria Bucciarelli. Of course, once the food came everyone's attention shifted to the meal and that attention was only broken by bouts of song.

Ivana Baldelli presented two awards to Maria Ierullo and Jennie Prosperine who she called, "Beautiful women...[who] plowed the road for all Italians."

The audience sat in quiet reverence as Baldelli said, "We could have three evenings to honour Maria Ierullo." As Ierullo stood so did every woman (and the three men) in attendance. Ierullo has had a long-standing reputation for excellence in the Ottawa Italian-Canadian community. She was the first woman to earn a real estate broker's license in the mid-1950's.

"The community is blessed by God and our Holy Family, the same way we've been brought up on the knees of our fathers," Ierullo said with tears in her eyes. She spoke of the village and togetherness of family and friends. She praised everyone's charity, hopes and dreams for the future of Italian-Canadians. When she finished, the clapping continued long after she took her seat.

Next, Jennie Prosperine was announced and received the same standing ovation response. She owned a store on Preston Street for five years, after which she too entered the real estate business. Prosperine now volunteers with the St. Anthony's Church Ladies Aid and many other organizations.

Prosperine spoke of the importance of the Italian community in Canada as well.

"I feel deeply honoured to accept this award....my work I've always considered a labour of love," she said eloquently.

Ierullo presented the last award to the Hon. Maria Minna. Minna was the first Italian woman in federal cabinet and is a role model for every young Italian-Canadian woman today.

In her speech, Minna gushed, "The warmth in here is fantastic...this award is something I will always treasure."

Minna posed a poignant question when she asked, "Where would this country be if not for immigrants...without us, where would Canada be today?" She talked about the problems that early Italian immigrants faced in Canada, but what we all ultimately have accomplished now.

"We've built a country...the Canada of tomorrow will be what we collectively make it because we believe we are this country," Minna said.

She ended her speech by exclaiming, "*Forza Canada!*" and everyone stood and cheered. Her speech brought tears to the eyes of many women in the audience and warmth to the hearts of all who had also experienced what she had in their early years in Canada.

Finally, Lee Farnworth thanked Minna for her attendance and everyone stood and cheered.

It was a night of fun, celebration and women. Older women shared their stories and younger women relived the events and listened with reverence. By the end of the night the feeling in the room was electric. Most of all, every woman felt at home and in the presence of a loving community.

Three exceptional Italian-Canadian Women: (LEFT) Maria Ierullo, (ABOVE) Jennie Prosperine, (BELOW) Maria Minna.

Photos: Fred Mastrangelo

Photos: Angelo Iencilli

Mamma Mia: A Filò

By Cecilia DiFelice

It's tough being a middle-aged Italian woman in this country. For one thing, we are trapped between our mothers with their old ways, old values and old attitudes and our kids with their new "I'm too smart to listen to you" ideas. Another problem we face is that we're not really Italian and not really Canadian. So we can't really claim the culture of either without somehow shortchanging both.

Sometimes it's so frustrating that I forget I have much to gain from all these divergent yet informative forces. This was recently made clear to me when my mother dragged me to "A Filò: Celebrating Italian Canadian Women of the Village." This dinner and gathering was intended, I am told, to serve many purposes: to honour Maria Minna, P.C., M.P., who is the first Italian Canadian woman to hold a federal cabinet post, to celebrate the lives and work of two prominent local Italian women, Jenny Prosperine and Maria Ierullo, for their contributions to our community, and finally to get together for a ladies' night during the long dark winter to eat well, sing and have a good time.

I must say that I was very impressed that evening by things I saw and heard. The food was great, the stories and speeches were inspiring and the singing heartfelt. But what I found the most interesting was what I actually learned about the women who were there, myself included.

When I first heard that there would be a dinner celebrating women and that a cabinet minister would be the speaker, I assumed that the talk would pertain to the important political, social and economic issues that concern our lives. Goodness knows these are serious and apply to our day-to-day world. I was right. There was a lot of talk about struggles with unfair pay, working conditions, stereotyping, social programs and lack of representation – not just for Italian-Canadians but for all minorities.

Each woman there had stories of hardship, suffering and loss. I look at my mother and it's hard to see her at this age (73) with a blue belt in tae kwon do, flying home to Italy each year for five months to look after her 90-year-old parents, and simultaneously remember when she worked ten-hour shifts in a sweat shop sewing bras for almost no money. I'm sure at the time my mother wasn't thinking about politics, sociology or economics. She was not concerned with issues of stereotyping or fair-trade practices. She was concerned with bringing home enough money to feed the family and pay the mortgage. That was the great immigrant dream, to own a piece of land in the new country and raise a successful family.

So that's what I learned about all the fine Italian-Canadian women at the dinner that night. We're political; we're interested in social and economic issues; and, we fight for important causes. We help our community and hold our culture together in this new country, but not for any "ideal" or theoretical concerns, although these certainly reflect our values. We work hard for very pragmatic reasons because we can and because we love our families and community. So here I am now looking back at that dinner and thinking that while I am in the middle of generational change and the middle of cultural diversity, I am also in a very good place to learn much from the people around me...if I keep my eyes and ears open.

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